

Fig. 3: The different phases which a product goes through in its entire life

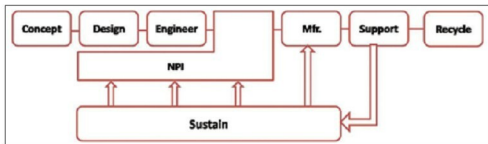


Fig. 4: Product lifecycle with an additional phase called recycle

share) and making the product meet global standards (as most of the products start addressing one single market and later the market is expanded).

Recycle. Classical product lifecycle phases emphasise on environment-friendly products being the norm. The product lifecycle today sports an additional phase called 'recycle' as shown in Fig. 4. As you can see, the last phase in the life of a product doesn't end abruptly but is terminated with recycle phase. The recycle phase ensures that the product doesn't harm the environment.

While majority of the lifecycle process will be the same (internally the way in which the implementations are done will change due to the environment-friendliness requirement), at the end of its life, the product gets out of the sustenance mode and moves to recycle mode, which could consist of the unit getting disassembled and recycled, the

unit getting refurbished and reused, or the unit getting disassembled and disposed of safely.

Factors impacting the environment

There are four important stages in a product's lifecycle that impact the environment in which the product works. These are raw material used in the product, manufacturing process used, use of the product, and end-of-life distribution or how the product is disposed of after it is discarded from use. If a product has to be made environment-friendly, or it has to meet global environmental standards, its design process should address these factors. In the next section, you will see how it can be done.

Design for environment

Design for resource conservation. This is the first and key step for designing a

WEEE directive

Together with RoHS, another directive dealing with the recycling of electrical and electronic equipment, called WEEE (Waste from Electrical and Electronic Equipment) directive, mandates post-use life of the product. The directive imposes the responsibility for the disposal of waste electrical and electronic equipment on the manufacturers of such equipment. Companies should establish an infrastructure for collecting WEEE, in such a way that "users of electrical and electronic equipment from private households have the possibility of returning WEEE at least free of charge." Also, the companies are compelled to use the collected waste in an ecological-friendly manner, either by ecological disposal or by reuse/refurbishment of the collected WEEE. Unless this issue is addressed early in the design phase, meeting this standard will be difficult.

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